

Barrier Breakers, March 20, 2026. Students from across Northeast Ohio before the first pitch of the morning.

Reach 8,000 students. Put the top 250 in one room.

Barrier Breakers is FinMango's one-day innovation challenge for Northeast Ohio high schoolers, heading into its fourth year. In 2026 we promoted it to roughly **8,000 students in 25+ high schools** across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas through our in-person classroom programming over the academic year. About **250 of the top students** from those classrooms showed up on March 20 to pitch real solutions to the costs that hold families back. For 2027 we are looking for partners: a host campus and sponsors. The details are on page 3.

~8,000

Students reached in person across 25+ high schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, where the event was promoted

~250

Top students from those classrooms who competed on event day

$20K+

Awarded in 2026 as cash to winning teams, grants to their schools, and scholarships

How the pipeline worked

In the classroom. FinMango teaches in-person financial education in 25+ high schools across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, reaching about 8,000 students over the academic year. That is where students first hear about Barrier Breakers.

The build. Teams of one to three pick a real barrier, such as transportation, housing, healthcare, or financial literacy, and build a solution to bring to the event.

Event day. Sixty-second pitches to a three-judge panel in the morning. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day in the afternoon, and the cash goes to the teams.

2026 at a glance

Event date	**March 20, 2026**
Students competing	**~250**
Platinum sponsor	**Valmark Financial Group · $25,000**
Awarded to students and schools	**$20,000+**
Demo Day finalists	**5 teams**
1st place award	**$7,500 cash, scholarship & school grant**
Minimum finalist award	**$1,250**

Partners on the day

Barrier Breakers 2026 was hosted on a university campus and presented by a platinum sponsor, Valmark Financial Group. Both were visible to every student in the building, from check-in through the awards.

- The host campus provided the venue, atrium, and auditorium for 250 students, teachers, and judges
- $25,000 platinum sponsorship funded the prize pool
- Two sponsor judges on the Demo Day panel
- Sponsor table and banner on the gallery floor all day, and sponsor judges presented awards

Where the money went

Barrier Breakers 2026 raised $30,000 in total: $25,000 from the platinum sponsor and $5,000 from two additional sponsors to help cover expenses. More than $20,000 went out as awards. The rest paid for the day itself: breakfast and lunch for 250 students plus their teachers and judges, materials, and the space.

In 2026 a sizable share of the awards went to scholarships through the host university rather than to the students in the room. Scholarships will not come out of the sponsorship budget in 2027. A host university may still offer them as its own contribution, but sponsor dollars go to the prizes and the event itself, managed directly by FinMango.

Platinum sponsor	**$25,000**
Two additional sponsors	**$5,000**
Total raised	**$30,000**
Awards: team cash, school grants, scholarships	**$20,000+**
The day: food, materials, space	**Remainder**



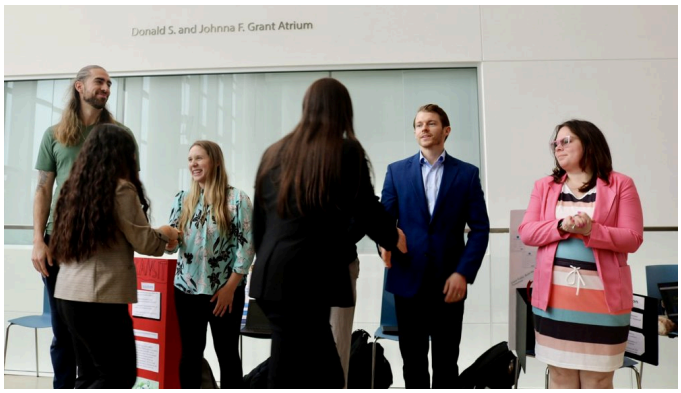
The platinum sponsor's table on the gallery floor, where students stopped between judging rounds.



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions from a judge.



Demo Day: five finalists present for five minutes each in front of every student in the room.



Awards: cash to the teams and a handshake from the judges, including the sponsor's.

Partnering on Barrier Breakers 2027

For 2027 we are selecting a new university host and recruiting sponsors, with the platinum presenting sponsorship at $25,000, the same level as 2026. The day keeps the same rhythm, a morning of pitches at the tables and Demo Day in the afternoon, but we have simplified the format for 2027: one pipeline for every team, no tracks to declare, one rubric for both rounds, and cash straight to the student teams. With no scholarship component, more of each sponsor dollar reaches the students in the room.

~$100

Per student in the room. What the $25,000 platinum sponsorship worked out to across the 250 students who competed in 2026

~$3

Per student reached, across the 8,000 who heard about Barrier Breakers in a FinMango classroom

25+

High schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas where FinMango teaches in person. The 2027 invitation goes wider

How a $25,000 platinum sponsorship is planned

Prize pool: five Demo Day teams and honorable mentions	$15,000
The day: breakfast, lunch, materials	$5,000
Student event assistant stipend	$2,500
Operations and contingency	$2,500
Total	**$25,000**

Approximate. Roughly six of every ten dollars go to students as prizes, and additional sponsors grow the prize pool.

What sponsorship funds

The prize pool. Cash to the five Demo Day teams, the largest share of the $20,000+ awarded in 2026.

Honorable mentions. A prize for each section's runner-up, so ten teams leave with something.

The day. Breakfast, lunch, and materials for 250 students plus their teachers and judges.

The next cohort. Classroom visits and the teacher toolkit that get schools to bring teams in the first place.

A student event assistant. A stipend for a college student, ideally from the host campus, who helps run logistics in the weeks before and on the day.

Operations and contingency. Venue fee if the host charges one, AV, printing, and a reserve for the unexpected.

FinMango is a very lean nonprofit with little overhead. The full sponsorship is invested in the event: prizes first, then the operations that make the day run, with a reserve for the unexpected.

Ways to partner

Host campus — **In kind or a venue fee**

One day in March: gallery space for 250 students plus teachers and judges, an auditorium for Demo Day, and bus parking. The host is named across the event and the site, and FinMango can pay a venue fee if required.

Platinum · presenting sponsor — **$25,000**

"Powered by" naming across the event and the site. Stage time at the awards, a seat on the judging panel, logo on every banner, flyer, and student handout, and first call on the 2028 slot.

Gold — **$10,000**

Funds a Demo Day prize in your name. Logo on the site and event banners, a seat on the judging panel, and a mention from the stage at the awards.

Silver — **$2,500**

Logo on the site and in the printed program, and an invitation to judge.

Name a prize — **Any amount**

Fund 1st place or the honorable mentions, and we announce it that way at the awards.

Where 2027 stands

Date and host campus	**TBA, new host being selected**
Judges	**Recruiting now, 15 needed**
Schools invited	**FinMango's 25+ and more**
Student applications	**Open once the date is set**
Prize pool	**Announced with sponsors**

Scott Glasgow, Founder & Executive Director, FinMango · competition@finmango.org · finmango.org/barrier-breakers

Levels are a starting point. If you would rather host the day, fund a named prize, or put your team on the floor as judges, we will build it around you.